SAMPLE

Sincerity: The Heart of the Deed

Ikhlas (إخلاص) in the Quran

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Introduction: The Purity

The Quran describes sincerity -- *Ikhlas* -- as the purity of the intention, the singularity of the devotion, and the exclusivity of the worship. The Quran says: "And they were not commanded except to worship Allah, sincere to Him in religion" (98:5). Sincerity is the heart -- the heart of the deed, the heart of the worship, and the heart of the faith. Without sincerity, the deed is hollow, the worship is empty, and the faith is shell. The sincerity is the difference between the deed that is accepted and the deed that is rejected, the worship that is received and the worship that is returned, and the faith that is living and the faith that is dead.

The word *Ikhlas* (إخلاص) comes from the root KH-L-S (خ ل ص), which carries the meanings of purity, sincerity, and exclusivity. The verb *khalasa* means to purify -- to purify from the mixture, to purify from the impurity, and to purify from the contamination. The noun *Ikhlas* signifies the sincerity -- the sincerity that purifies the intention, the sincerity that purifies the devotion, and the sincerity that purifies the worship. *Al-Ikhlas* is the sincerity that is the quality of the believer -- the quality that makes the deed pure, the quality that makes the worship singular, and the quality that makes the faith real.

This book -- the seventh in the Lessons from the Qur'an sub-series -- explores sincerity as the Quran describes it. It examines the name *Ikhlas*, the foundation of worshiping Allah alone, the opposite of sincerity (shirk and showing off), the relationship between the deed and the intention, the contrast between the sincere and the hypocrite, the prophetic models of devotion, the test of sincerity when the deed costs, the reward of sincerity, and the lesson -- how to live in the sincerity.

The Quran's treatment of sincerity reveals the dimension of the purity -- the purity that is the intention, the purity that is the devotion, and the purity that is the relationship with Allah. The sincerity is not the perfection of the deed but the purity of the heart -- the heart that is for Allah, the heart that is pure from the show, and the heart that is singular in the devotion. The person who is sincere is the person whose heart is pure -- pure in the intention, pure in the devotion, and pure in the worship.

The first chapter begins with the name itself -- what *Ikhlas* means, how the Quran uses it, and what the name reveals about the purity it describes.

Chapter 1: The Name -- Ikhlas and the Meaning of Sincerity

The word *Al-Ikhlas* (الإخلاص) comes from the root KH-L-S (خ ل ص), which carries the meanings of purity, sincerity, exclusivity, and purification. The verb *khalasa* means to purify -- to purify from the mixture, to purify from the impurity, and to purify from the contamination. The noun *Ikhlas* signifies the sincerity -- the sincerity that purifies the intention from the show, the sincerity that purifies the devotion from the mixture, and the sincerity that purifies the worship from the contamination. The name tells the listener: this is not the surface purity of the appearance but the deep purity of the heart, not the outer correctness of the deed but the inner sincerity of the intention, and not the form of the worship but the spirit of the devotion.

The Quran uses the word *Ikhlas* and its derivatives extensively. As the command: "And they were not commanded except to worship Allah, sincere to Him in religion" (98:5). As the quality: "And mention in the Book, Musa. Indeed, he was chosen, and he was a messenger, a prophet" (19:51, where *mukhlasan* means chosen/purified). As the dedication: "And sincerity to Me in religion" (39:14, broader context of 39:2, 39:11). As the description of the believers: "Say: Indeed, my prayer, my sacrifice, my living, and my dying are for Allah, Lord of the worlds" (6:162). Each usage places *Ikhlas* as the central quality of the believer -- the quality that defines the relationship with Allah, the quality that determines the acceptance of the deed, and the quality that distinguishes the true from the false.

The *Ikhlas* is the purification -- the purification of the intention from the show, the purification of the devotion from the mixture, and the purification of the worship from the contamination. The Quran says: "And they were not commanded except to worship Allah, sincere to Him in religion" (98:5). The purification is the refining: the refining that removes the impurity, the refining that removes the dross, and the refining that removes the alloy. The purification is the singularity: the singularity that is for Allah alone, the singularity that is not shared, and the singularity that is not mixed. The purification is the sincerity: the sincerity that is the pure, the sincerity that is the unmixed, and the sincerity that is the uncontaminated.

The *Ikhlas* is the exclusivity -- the exclusivity that reserves the worship for Allah, the exclusivity that reserves the devotion for the Lord, and the exclusivity that reserves the intention for the Master. The Quran says: "Say: Indeed, my prayer, my sacrifice, my living, and my dying are for Allah, Lord of the worlds" (6:162). The exclusivity is the reservation: the reservation that gives the worship to Allah alone, the reservation that gives the devotion to Allah alone, and the reservation that gives the intention to Allah alone. The exclusivity is the singularity: the singularity that is not divided, the singularity that is not shared, and the singularity that is not split. The exclusivity is the devotion: the devotion that is whole, the devotion that is complete, and the devotion that is entire.

The Quran contains a surah named *Al-Ikhlas* (Surah 112) -- the surah that defines the purity of the faith: "Say: He is Allah, the One. Allah, the Eternal Refuge. He neither begets nor is born. And there is none comparable to Him." The surah is the declaration: the declaration of the oneness, the declaration of the uniqueness, and the declaration of the purity. The surah is the foundation: the foundation of the sincerity, the foundation that Allah is One, and the foundation that the worship is for the One. The surah is the model: the model of the pure faith, the model of the pure devotion, and the model of the pure sincerity that is the quality of the believer and the way of the faithful.

The sincerity is the condition of the acceptance -- the acceptance that requires the pure intention, the acceptance that requires the sincere devotion, and the acceptance that requires the singular worship. The Quran says: "So whoever hopes for the meeting with his Lord, let him do righteous work and not associate in the worship of his Lord anyone" (18:110). The acceptance is the condition: the condition that the deed is for Allah, the condition that the intention is for Allah, and the condition that the worship is for Allah. The acceptance is the reward: the reward that is given to the sincere, the reward that is given to the pure, and the reward that is given to the devoted. The person who is sincere is the person whose deed is accepted -- accepted because the intention is pure, accepted because the devotion is singular, and accepted because the worship is for Allah.

The Quran describes the denier's relationship with sincerity: "And most of them do not believe in Allah except while they associate others with Him" (12:106). The denier does not have sincerity -- does not purify, does not singularize, and does not devote. The denier lives in the mixture -- lives in the show, lives in the sharing, and lives in the contamination. The name *Ikhlas* is the refutation of the mixture -- the refutation that the purity is required, the refutation that the singularity is necessary, and the refutation that the devotion is the truth.

The name *Ikhlas* is the foundation -- the foundation of the deed, the foundation of the worship, and the foundation of the faith. The Quran says: "And they were not commanded except to worship Allah, sincere to Him in religion" (98:5). The foundation is the purity: the purity that makes the deed real, the purity that makes the worship true, and the purity that makes the faith living. The foundation is the sincerity: the sincerity that is the heart, the sincerity that is the core, and the sincerity that is the essence. The foundation is the quality: the quality that defines the believer, the quality that distinguishes the faithful, and the quality that identifies the sincere.
